



The first land plants appeared around the same time as the first insects. The earliest liverworts, relatives of the **common kettlewort** and **common liverwort**, evolved about 470 million years ago. They did not have roots, stems, or flowers but lived in damp places and simply absorbed water through their surface. Later came hornworts and mosses, many of which had more

complex, leaflike shoots, like those of the modern **tamarisk moss** and the **glittering wood moss**. Without veins to carry water and nutrients from the soil to the shoots, these plants remain small. However, club mosses and horsetails, such as the **marsh clubmoss**, **fir clubmoss**, and **meadow horsetail**, have veins running up their stems and so grow taller.



Sponglike moss can store huge amounts of water.

Common haircap



Sphagnum

This unusually tall moss can grow up to 15¾ in (40 cm).



HEALING MOSS

Sphagnum moss is absorbent and very acidic, so it prevents the growth of bacteria and fungi. During World War I (1914–1918), bandages were sometimes wrapped around sphagnum moss and used as dressings for soldiers. This stopped their wounds from becoming infected and helped them heal faster.



Dressing made of sphagnum moss



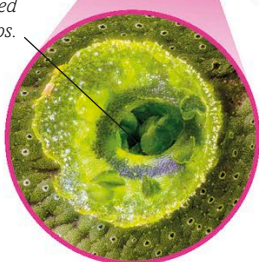
Sphagnum bandage roll

Scientists **study** the common liverwort to learn how **plants evolved**.



Common liverwort

The young plants growing inside these cups are splashed out by raindrops.



Cuplike structure

Spore-producing cones grow at the tips of fertile stems.

These tiny upright stems look like little conifers.



Fir clubmoss

Each capsule produces thousands of tiny spores.

Velvet feather-moss



Meadow horsetail

